

Breaking News Publication SOP - MCN News

Purpose

This document defines the expedited publication process used for time-sensitive breaking news, where the standard Editorial Review and Fact-Checking SOP's normal turnaround times don't apply.

What Qualifies as Breaking News

A story qualifies for the expedited process only if it meets both of the following:

- Time-sensitivity: the story concerns an ongoing or just-concluded event where minutes of delay materially reduce its news value (e.g. a natural disaster, a major accident, an official announcement already public elsewhere).
- Duty Editor confirmation: the on-shift Duty Editor confirms breaking-news status before the expedited process begins - a reporter cannot self-designate a story as breaking news.

Expedited Publication Process

1. Reporter submits a short initial draft (headline + verified core facts only, minimum 2 sources for the core fact) directly to the Duty Editor, bypassing the full Fact-Check Desk queue.
2. Duty Editor reviews for the same source-verification bar as the standard SOP but targets a 15-minute turnaround, not 4 hours.
3. Once published, the story is flagged internally as "developing" and routed to the Fact-Check Desk for a full retroactive check within 2 hours of initial publication.
4. Any fact that fails the retroactive check must be corrected immediately, following the Correction/Retraction Escalation SOP - a breaking-news designation does not exempt a story from correction requirements.

Update Cadence

Once a breaking story is live, the assigned reporter or a designated follow-up reporter must post a material update (new confirmed fact, or an explicit "no update" note) at least every 30 minutes while the story remains in "developing" status, so readers aren't left on stale information during a fast-moving event.